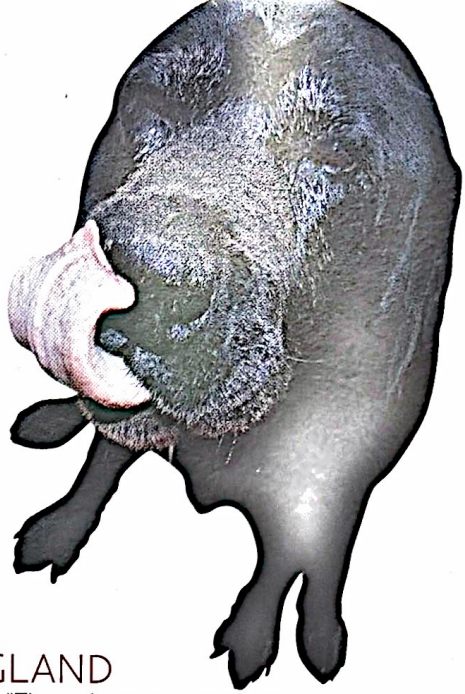
APPROXIMATE METEOROLOGY

Climatic Crapshoot

A roundup of winter forecasts from the scientific to the sophomoric.



WHY IS MOTHER NATURE SUCH A DAFT AND FICKLE WENCH? ONE MINUTE SHE'S churning out powder. The next minute she's serving up a three-week dry spell. To beat her at her own game, we employed three different forecasting techniques. First, we talked to the country's leading meteorologists. Then we examined weather lore, finding parcels of science between the lines. Finally, we made a giant map of the U.S. in the backyard of *Skiing* editor-in-chief Marc Peruzzi, placed a few Milk-Bones on said map, and released Kramer, his daft and fickle 15-year-old lab (his dog-treat consumption means heavy snowfall). Here's the outlook for next season. **—JEFF FOSS**

PACIFIC NORTHWEST

EXPERT'S TAKE: "The expected La Niña conditions will bring above-average precipitation and lower-than-average temperatures to this region," says Dr. Jeff Masters, director of meteorology at WeatherUnderground.com. "That translates to above-average snowfall."

FOLK FORECAST: *"Seagull, seagull, on the sand...it's never good weather when you're on the land."* **TRANSLATION:** If coastal conditions are harsh enough to ground seabirds, moisture-laden storms could be on their way. We went bird-watching and got shat upon from on high twice—not a good sign, according to this theory.

MILK-BONE METHOD: Kramer's hips let out momentarily above Oregon. A positive indicator? We say yes.

NEW ENGLAND

EXPERT'S TAKE: "The early-season outlook hints at average precipitation and above-average temperatures," says Julie Bologna, meteorologist and co-author of *The Complete Idiot's Guide to Extreme Weather*. "This could spell snow, but it could also mean some periods of rain."

FOLK FORECAST: *"A coming storm your shooting corns presage; aches will throb, your hollow tooth will rage."*

TRANSLATION: The falling pressure that precedes a storm can aggravate sensitive joints and cavities. Crusty East skiers' joints and fillings were hurting just thinking about those icy New England landings, signifying a snowy year.

MILK-BONE METHOD: Rather than snatch his treat, Kramer slobbered from Maine all the way down to the Poconos, suggesting another soggy season.

SIERRA NEVADAS

EXPERT'S TAKE: "The odds of an El Niño event happening this winter are low—probably around 20 percent," Dr. Todd Crawford, head of Seasonal Forecasting at Weather Services International, says. "Unfortunately, this tilts the odds toward a dry winter in the Sierra Nevadas."

FOLK FORECAST: *"A ring around the sun or moon means rain or snow approaching soon."* **TRANSLATION:** When celestial bodies appear to be haloed, ice crystals are forming at high altitudes. We squinted at the moon for hours and saw only what looked like Keith Richards's craggy face, which we'll take as a sign of a sorry-ass season.

MILK-BONE METHOD: Who needs El Niño when you have El Perro? Kramer napped on Tahoe for 45 minutes. Then he rolled over and snatched up his Milk-Bone. A bountiful winter is certain!

ROCKIES

EXPERT'S TAKE: "There should be a large mass of cold air over much of the U.S. at the start of the season," says Michael Ferrari, vice president of Applied Technology at Weather Trends International. "November snowfall could be a foot higher than in 2006."

FOLK FORECAST: *"Woolly bear, woolly bear, show us your bands; thin stripes mean snowflakes throughout the land."* **TRANSLATION:** In the world of folkloric forecasting, narrow stripes on certain caterpillars can signify a harsh winter. Kramer ate our specimens, so the forecast calls for a runny, irregular season.

MILK-BONE METHOD: Our hero walked right over Colorado, wandered up to Montana, and got lost. Not a good sign.

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